MODULE 05 · DOMAIN 1 - PROMPTING AND TASK EXECUTION

Iterating, and Matching Strategy to the Task

How to improve a draft on purpose, when to stop, and why analysis, research, drafting and brainstorming each need a different kind of prompt.

DOMAIN 1 of 7 EXAM WEIGHT 14% MODULE 5 of 33

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The first draft is a measurement, not a verdict.

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Iteration as a controlled experiment

- **Name the weakness.** Not "it's not great", but "the tone is too formal for supervisors".
- **Change one thing.** The element most likely to cause that weakness.
- **Compare against your original criteria**, not just against the last draft.
- **Keep a short log:** what changed, and what happened.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Each round should target a specific, diagnosed weakness. More rounds alone prove nothing.

Prompt roulette, or a controlled change?

PROMPT ROULETTE

Rewrite it all again

- Five things changed at once
- Judged by gut feel
- Nothing written down
- A good draft cannot be repeated

CONTROLLED ITERATION

One change, measured

- One element changed
- Judged against criteria
- Change and effect logged
- The good version is reproducible

THE TIEBREAKER

Change one thing at a time, or you will never know which change helped.

Match the fix to the weakness

IF THE DRAFT IS...	THE MOST DIRECT FIX
The wrong tone	Name the audience and concrete tone words; or show an example
Using the wrong terms	Supply the house glossary and require its terms
The wrong shape	Specify the structure, or show a marked example
Missing something	Name the missing item explicitly in the task
Too generic	Add context and the real material
Too long or too short	State a length, and say why

ON THE EXAM

The strongest refinements are concrete: an example, a named audience, a tone word, a glossary.

Keep what already works

- **Most of the draft was accepted?** Revise only the parts that were flagged.
- **Say so explicitly:** "Revise sections 3 and 5 only. Leave everything else unchanged."
- **Ask for a change list**, so the next reviewer sees exactly what moved.
- **Regenerating the whole thing** risks breaking what was already approved.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Targeted revision protects accepted work and makes the next review fast.

The iteration loop

01
Describe
Task, context, format, examples.

›

02
Generate
Claude produces a draft.

›

03
Compare
Against your original criteria.

›

04
Diagnose
Name the specific weakness.

›

05
Change one thing
Then go round again.

ON THE EXAM

This is module two's Description-Discernment loop, made into a routine.

When to stop iterating

KEEP GOING WHEN

Each round helps

- Weaknesses are shrinking
- Each change has a clear target
- The criteria are within reach

STOP OR SWITCH WHEN

Returns have run out

- Flat for several rounds
- Drifting further from the target
- The gap is missing information

THE TIEBREAKER

Flat for several rounds: change approach or bring in a person. Getting worse: go back to the best version.

Let Claude check its own work, then check it yourself

- **Anthropic suggests a self-check:** "Before you finish, verify your answer against these criteria."
- **Give it your criteria**, so the check measures what matters to you.
- **Useful for completeness:** did every required section appear?
- **Not a substitute for your review.** A model checking itself is not verification.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A self-check catches omissions cheaply. Accountability for the output still sits with you.

Match the strategy to the task

TASK TYPE	PROMPTING STRATEGY	WATCH OUT FOR
Analysis	Data, question, show reasoning	Unstated assumptions
Research	Questions first; sources, confidence	Unsourced claims
Drafting	Audience, tone, structure, example	Generic house-style drift
Brainstorming	Open, many varied ideas	Judging ideas too early
Fixed reporting	Rigid template, same fields	Structure changing monthly

ON THE EXAM

One template cannot serve every task type. The task decides the strategy.

Open prompt, or template?

OPEN AND EXPLORATORY

When you want novelty

- Early-stage ideas
- A new market or service
- Many options to choose from
- Judgement comes later

RIGID AND TEMPLATED

When you want consistency

- The same report every month
- Fixed fields or schema
- Comparable across periods
- Easy to check line by line

THE TIEBREAKER

Novelty wants an open prompt. Consistency wants a template.

One template for everything

- **Marketing uses one prompt template** for newsletters, brainstorms and data summaries.
- **Brainstorms come back narrow**, because the template asks for one polished answer.
- **Data summaries come back chatty**, because the template asks for a warm newsletter tone.
- **The fix:** a small library, one template per task type, each built for its job.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A single template gives uneven results across task types. Adapt the strategy to the task.

Thinking and effort are strategy levers too

- **Effort levels** (Low to Max) and a **Thinking** toggle sit in Claude's model picker, where the model supports them.
- **Turn them up** for multi-step reasoning: weighing causes, comparing options, careful analysis.
- **Turn them down** for quick drafts and simple rewrites. More thinking costs time and usage.
- **Anthropic's advice:** general guidance such as "think this through carefully" often beats scripted steps.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Match the depth of reasoning to the task, just as you match the prompt to it.

A client reviewed Halden's Claude-drafted mobilisation plan for a new office contract. They accepted almost all of it.

They flagged two concerns: weekend cover is unclear, and the keyholding arrangements are missing.

Which approach will produce the strongest next version?

A Ask Claude to revise only those two areas, keep everything else unchanged, and list what changed

B Regenerate the whole plan from the original prompt, with the client's comments added

C Start a new chat and write a completely new prompt for the plan

D Add the client's comments and the team's own wish list, then regenerate everything

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which approach will produce the strongest next version?

A Ask Claude to revise only those two areas, keep everything else unchanged, and list what changed

Fixes what was flagged, protects what was accepted, eases re-review.

B Regenerate the whole plan from the original prompt, with the client's comments added

Risks changing approved sections nobody asked to touch.

C Start a new chat and write a completely new prompt for the plan

Throws away a plan the client has already mostly accepted.

D Add the client's comments and the team's own wish list, then regenerate everything

Adds unrequested changes and reopens agreed content.

THE SIGNAL

"Accepted almost all of it": protect the accepted work and fix only what was flagged.

> Halden's operations team has rewritten its weekly-report prompt four times, changing the audience, length, format and examples in every round.
>
> The latest draft is better, but nobody knows why, and next week's report came out worse again.

Which practice would have helped most?

A Switching to a more capable model for the weekly report

B Asking Claude which of the four prompts is the best one

C Rewriting the prompt more often, so a good version turns up sooner

D Changing one element per round and recording its effect against the report's criteria

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which practice would have helped most?

A Switching to a more capable model for the weekly report

The problem is the method, not the model's capability.

B Asking Claude which of the four prompts is the best one

Claude cannot know which version suited the readers.

C Rewriting the prompt more often, so a good version turns up sooner

More roulette. Still no idea what works.

D Changing one element per round and recording its effect against the report's criteria

Shows which change helped, so the good version can be kept.

THE SIGNAL

"Nobody knows why": too many changes at once, and nothing recorded.

> Halden's learning team has refined a course-outline prompt seven times. The last four versions made no real difference.
>
> Every outline still lacks the site-specific hazards trainers need. Those hazards are not in any material given to Claude.

What is the best next step?

A Keep refining the wording until the hazards start to appear

B Get the site hazard registers from the safety team, or have a safety adviser add the hazards

C Switch to the most capable model and repeat the last prompt

D Accept the outline as final, since iteration has stopped helping

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best next step?

A Keep refining the wording until the hazards start to appear

Wording cannot produce information Claude does not have.

B Get the site hazard registers from the safety team, or have a safety adviser add the hazards

Changes approach: supplies the missing information or a person who has it.

C Switch to the most capable model and repeat the last prompt

No model knows Halden's site hazards.

D Accept the outline as final, since iteration has stopped helping

Stops, but ships an outline missing safety-critical content.

THE SIGNAL

A plateau caused by missing information: change approach, do not reword.

> Halden's team leads each propose a prompting strategy for a different task.
>
> Their manager wants to back the proposal where the strategy best fits the task.

Which pairing is most appropriate?

A Ideas to win back a lost client: an open prompt asking for many varied options, judged later

B The monthly compliance return with fixed fields: a fresh open-ended prompt each month

C A summary of new employment rules: ask Claude to answer from memory, with no sources

D An analysis of absence data: ask for conclusions only, with no reasoning or assumptions

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which pairing is most appropriate?

A Ideas to win back a lost client: an open prompt asking for many varied options, judged later

Brainstorming wants breadth first, judgement afterwards.

B The monthly compliance return with fixed fields: a fresh open-ended prompt each month

Fixed fields want a rigid template, or the shape will drift.

C A summary of new employment rules: ask Claude to answer from memory, with no sources

New rules may postdate training. Research of that kind needs sources.

D An analysis of absence data: ask for conclusions only, with no reasoning or assumptions

Hides exactly what a reviewer needs to check.

THE SIGNAL

Novelty wants open prompts; fixed fields want templates; research wants sources.

> Halden's safety committee asked a manager to "look into what other firms do about lone working". After a conversation, the goal is clear.
>
> They want a structured comparison of how five large facilities firms publicly describe their lone-working arrangements. They do not want new policy ideas.

Which strategy best fits the clarified task?

A Brainstorm new lone-working policies with Claude for the committee

B Ask Claude to describe each firm's arrangements from what it already knows

C Draft Halden's revised lone-working policy straight away

D Research each firm's published information, citing sources and noting confidence for each finding

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which strategy best fits the clarified task?

A Brainstorm new lone-working policies with Claude for the committee

The committee said explicitly: no new policy ideas.

B Ask Claude to describe each firm's arrangements from what it already knows

Unsourced, possibly out of date, and not checkable.

C Draft Halden's revised lone-working policy straight away

A different task, and premature.

D Research each firm's published information, citing sources and noting confidence for each finding

A research strategy: structured, sourced and honest about certainty.

THE SIGNAL

A comparison of what others publish is research: sources and confidence, not ideas.

> A Halden account manager wants to understand why a client's satisfaction scores fell this quarter. She has survey comments and site visit logs, and three possible explanations.
>
> She needs a careful, reasoned comparison of the three. Speed does not matter.

Which setting best fits the task?

A The lowest effort setting, so the answer comes back quickly

B The lightest, fastest model, to save usage

C A higher effort setting with thinking on, asking Claude to state its assumptions

D Thinking turned off, so the answer is more direct

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which setting best fits the task?

A The lowest effort setting, so the answer comes back quickly

Optimises for speed, which she said does not matter.

B The lightest, fastest model, to save usage

Suits volume and speed, not careful multi-step reasoning.

C A higher effort setting with thinking on, asking Claude to state its assumptions

Deeper reasoning for a weighing task, with assumptions open to checking.

D Thinking turned off, so the answer is more direct

Removes the reasoning the task most needs.

THE SIGNAL

"Careful, reasoned comparison" and "speed does not matter": turn reasoning up.

In five lines

- **Iterate like an experiment:** name the weakness, change one thing, compare with the criteria.
- **Concrete fixes win:** an example, an audience, tone words, a glossary.
- **Protect accepted work.** Revise only what was flagged, and list the changes.
- **Plateau: change approach. Drifting: revert to the best version.**
- **The task picks the strategy:** open for ideas, templates for fixed reports, sources for research.

> COMING UP
>
> Domain 1 complete. Next, Domain 2: judging what comes back, starting with criteria.